



### ▲ THE AZTECS AND CORTÉS

Spanish conquistador (conqueror) Hernán Cortés arrived in Mexico in 1519. He made alliances with Indigenous people, such as the Tlaxcala, and with their help was able to capture the Aztec capital of Tenochtitlan (see p.92) after a 79-day siege in 1521. He renamed the former center of the Aztec Empire as Mexico City.



### ▲ CONQUEST OF THE MAYA

When the Spanish reached Central America in the 16th century, instead of a single Maya kingdom, they found an alliance of multiple cities scattered around the Yucatán Peninsula. This meant that the invaders had to fight individual strongholds to bring the Maya under their control. The conflict lasted 170 years and only ended in 1697 when the last Maya city—Tayasal in modern-day Guatemala—was defeated.

# Conquest of the Americas

When Europeans first traveled to the Americas in the late 15th century, Indigenous cultures thrived in modern-day Mexico and Central and South America. Stories of their wealth soon reached Europe, and Spanish explorers flocked to the new lands. They invaded these territories, ultimately leading to the collapse of the Indigenous civilizations.

By the 16th century, Indigenous cultures such as the Aztecs and Inca (see pp.92–93), and Maya (see pp.38–39) had developed sophisticated civilizations. However, they were not prepared for the European invaders, who arrived armed with guns, wearing armor, and riding horses. An even bigger threat came from new diseases brought into the Americas from Europe, such as smallpox, that killed hundreds of thousands.

The Spaniards made use of internal rivalries to conquer Mexico and other parts of the Americas with Indigenous

support. Once the native populations had been defeated, the Spanish set about colonizing the conquered lands. The Spanish government introduced a system called *encomienda*, in which conquered Indigenous laborers worked for the settlers, and were taught the Christian faith. Spanish settlers took advantage of this arrangement, treating the Indigenous workers horribly. The system only lasted a few decades in some places, but was not abolished throughout the Spanish Empire until the late 18th century.